



TIME TO RELAX AND RECHARGE | EXERCISE 2

Diaphragmatic Breathwork

Simple Techniques to Work on Your Diaphragm

The diaphragm plays a crucial role in effective breathing and oxygen exchange. When you inhale it contracts and moves downwards creating space for the lungs to help air flow in. When you exhale, it relaxes, moves upwards and pushes air out of the lungs.

During an in-breath the lower belly expands first, followed by your side ribs then the intercostal muscles/chest- your belly should move outwards before there is any movement in the chest. Remember, you are not engaging your stomach muscles, they stay relaxed, it's the downwards movement of the diaphragm as the lungs fill with air that causes the belly to expand.



Technique 1: Diaphragmatic Breath Exercise

To engage your diaphragm effectively when you inhale

1. Sit or Lie on the floor in a comfortable position free from distraction. Relax your shoulders. Place one hand on your chest. Place the other hand on your abdomen.
2. Trying not to control your breathing, take notice of the rise and fall of your hands, the length of each in- and out-breath and how you use your nose and mouth to breathe.
3. Then inhale deeply through your nose into your abdomen and laterally into the lower rib cage and back toward the spine. Imagine expanding the entire surface area and dome of the diaphragm to make room for your expanding lungs. Notice how the hand on your abdomen raises higher than the hand on your chest. Try not to push out with your stomach muscles.
4. Take time to exhale passively through the nose, relax the diaphragm, let the stomach return to its starting position.

Repeat steps three and four for a duration of five minutes. With practice, you should aim to inhale for 5.5 seconds, then exhale 5.5 seconds without a pause between the breaths.



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Technique 2: Diaphragmatic Stretch Exercise

To improve lung capacity and diaphragm function, as well as the intercostal, oblique and abdominal muscles

1. Stand Tall: Stand with your feet hip-width apart.
2. Turn your palms towards the floor, elbows facing outwards, middle fingers touching, arms straight.
3. Breathe in through your nose, feel your belly rise whilst lifting your hands above your head, arms straight, middle fingers touching, palms facing away from you.
4. Push your arms towards the sky for 4 seconds whilst holding your breath -feel the stretch across your middle and diaphragm, but don't push from the shoulders.
5. Exhale slowly whilst circling your arms round and down by your sides..

Repeat 5 times.